Finnish-Soviet War

Stalin knew that his country's pact with Germany would not last indefinitely. Therefore, he sought a buffer zone to protect his nation against any future German attack. By June 1940, he had bullied Estonia, Latvia and Lithuania into cooperation and swiftly followed up by full annexation. However, Finland resisted and refused to submit to Soviet demands. The 105-day 'Winter War' began with Russia's attack on Finland on November 30th, 1939. Russia expected an easy victory like what the Germans had experienced against the Poles, but were surprised by their opponents. The Finnish army fought bravely and showed expertise in guerrilla warfare. It was difficult for the Soviets to defeat the Finnish. Historians suggest that Stalin had purged the military in the 1930s, which had a negative impact on soldiers. Along with poor equipment that froze in the plummeting temperatures, the Soviets learned a hard but useful lesson. They were eventually able to subdue the Finns in March 1940 by sheer weight of numbers alone.